Cold calling

Involving everyone in questioning

Use cold calling to make classroom questions an invitation for everyone to think. Build a warm, predictable question–pause–name routine and use answers to guide teaching.

How to do it well

1 Establish the rationale and norms. Explain that everyone thinks, the teacher selects and uncertainty is a normal starting point—not a public trap.

2 Ask the whole class. Pose a clear factual, conceptual or reasoning question before naming a pupil.

3 Protect wait time. Allow at least several seconds, and longer for complex prompts; scan the room while everyone prepares.

4 Invite warmly. Name the pupil with open, supportive language and listen without interrupting the first attempt.

5 Probe or connect. Ask for evidence, a clearer term, a connection or another pupil's build; require the class to listen.

6 Support successful re-entry. Use paired or written rehearsal, pre-call, a prompt, a second pupil's answer and a return to the original pupil when confidence or knowledge is fragile.

What this sounds like

"Without hands up or calling out, everyone think: which evidence supports that claim? [Pause.] Priya, what did you choose and why?"

Classroom example. A teacher asks everyone to consider why a line of code fails, pauses, then names a pupil. An incomplete response receives a targeted clue and preparation time before the teacher returns. The routine keeps the public answer supportive while requiring everyone to think; it is not used to catch out a pupil who was distracted.

Top tips that make the technique work

Front-load the response mode. Tell students to think without calling out before posing the question.

Ask before naming. Everyone prepares, then you select the respondent.

Use preparation strategically. Silent thinking, a jot or partner rehearsal helps students develop a response before public contribution.

Distribute questions deliberately. Sample across the room, avoiding repeated reliance on confident pupils or random selection without a purpose.

Respond to uncertainty constructively. Prompt, provide rehearsal or a Second Chance; do not turn a difficult answer into public punishment.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Keep the routine predictable and supportive.	Using a question as a sanction for talking.
Ask follow-up questions about the reasoning.	Naming a pupil before others have had time to think.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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